



SCHOOL FOR THE GIFTED – ENGLISH LANGUAGE
CLASS: SS1
TOPIC: WORD STRESS

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1. Introduction to Word Stress

Word stress refers to the way a particular syllable in a word is pronounced **with more force, louder, longer, or at a higher pitch** than the other syllables.

English is a stress-timed language; therefore, correct stress is very important for good pronunciation and understanding.

Example

- In the word *teacher* → **TEA**-cher
The first syllable is stressed.

If stress is placed wrongly, meaning may be unclear or may change completely.

2. Meaning of Syllable

A **syllable** is a part of a word that contains one vowel sound and is pronounced at one beat.

Words and their syllables

- go – 1 syllable
- Eng-lish – 2 syllables
- com-pu-ter – 3 syllables
- e-du-ca-tion – 4 syllables

Stress always falls on **one syllable only** in a word.

3. Importance of Word Stress

Word stress helps to:

- pronounce English correctly,
- differentiate between similar words,
- understand spoken English easily,
- speak confidently in reading and conversation,
- score high marks in Oral English examinations such as WAEC/NECO in future.

4. Features of a Stressed Syllable

A stressed syllable usually has:

- greater loudness,
- longer duration,
- clearer vowel quality,
- sometimes a change in pitch.

Unstressed syllables are weak and often contain the sound /ə/ called **schwa**.

5. Rules Guiding Word Stress in English

Although English stress is sometimes irregular, the following general rules guide SS1 learners:

Rule 1: Two-Syllable Nouns and Adjectives

Most **two-syllable nouns and adjectives** are stressed on the **first syllable**.

Examples:

- **T**able
- **DO**ctor
- **PRE**tty
- **CLE**ver
- **QUI**et

Rule 2: Two-Syllable Verbs

Most **two-syllable verbs** take stress on the **second syllable**.

Examples:

- re**LAX**
- be**GIN**
- for**GET**
- col**LECT**

Rule 3: Words Ending in –ion, –sion, –tion

Stress comes on the syllable **before** the ending.

Examples:

- edu**C**ation
- rev**I**sion
- situa**T**ion
- deci**S**ion

Rule 4: Words Ending in –ic, –ical

Stress falls on the syllable before –ic.

Examples:

- geo**GRA**phic
- dra**MA**tic
- eco**NO**mic
- bio**LO**gical

Rule 5: Compound Words

i. Compound Nouns

Stress is on the **first part**.

- **BLACK**board
- **FOOT**ball
- **CLASS**room
- **NEWS**paper

ii. Compound Verbs

Stress is on the **second part**.

- over**FLOW**

- under**STAND**
- out**GROW**

Rule 6: Prefix Words

In many words with prefixes (un-, re-, dis-, im-), stress remains on the **root word**, not on the prefix.

- un**HAP**py
- dis**LIKE**
- im**PORT**ant

6. Stress and Change in Meaning

Some English words change meaning according to stress placement.

Word	Stress Pattern	Meaning
REcord	RE -cord (noun)	a written account
reCORD	re- CORD (verb)	to keep account
PREsent	PRE -sent (noun)	Gift
preSENT	pre- SENT (verb)	to introduce

Students must master these differences for Oral English.

7. Examples of Word Stress Patterns

Three-Syllable Words

- **BEA**Utiful – stress 1st
- to**MA**to – stress 2nd
- under**STAND** – stress 3rd

Four-Syllable Words

- exami**NA**tion
- ge**O**graphy
- com**MU**nicate

8. Weak Forms in Stress

Grammatical words like *to, of, for, a, an, was, were* are usually **unstressed** in sentences.

- I went **to** school → /tə/ not /tu:/
- cup **of** tea → /əv/

9. Guidelines for Identifying Stress in Exams

To answer stress questions:

1. Divide the word into syllables.
2. Listen for the louder part.
3. Use dictionary marks ' before stressed syllable.
4. Remember noun/verb contrast rules.

10. Summary

- Word stress is the emphasis on one syllable.
- English pronunciation depends greatly on correct stress.
- Certain endings and compound words follow regular stress rules.

- Wrong stress can change meaning.
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11. Evaluation Exercises

Exercise A: Mark the stressed syllable

1. computer
 2. situation
 3. classroom
 4. begin
 5. economic
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Exercise B: Choose the correct option

Indicate whether the stress shows noun or verb.

- present
 - record
 - export
 - import
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Exercise C: Syllable Counting

Break into syllables and mark stress:

- examination
 - geographic
 - communication
 - footballer
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Note to Students:

Regular practice in reading aloud and using a good dictionary will help you master word stress.
